The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Takaichi Sanae won a landslide in **Japan's snap election**. The leader of the Liberal Democratic Party, who became prime minister a few months ago, secured a two-thirds "supermajority" in the lower house. The main centre-left opposition, the Central Reform Alliance, lost half its seats. Armed with a fresh mandate, Ms Takaichi is expected implement a looser fiscal policy. Japanese stocks surged on the news.

Jimmy Lai, one of Hong Kong's most famous pro-democracy advocates, was sentenced to a total of 20 years in prison for collusion with foreign forces and sedition, crimes under the territory's national-security law. He was convicted in December. The 78-year-old media mogul has already spent more than 1,800 days behind bars for unauthorised assembly and fraud.

Anutin Charnvirakul, **Thailand's** prime minister, declared victory in a general election for his conservative Bhumjaithai Party. With nearly all votes counted, Bhumjaithai looked set to win about 192 seats, with the reformist People's Party taking 117. The result is a blow for the People's Party, which, under a different name, was blocked by the army-appointed Senate from taking power in 2023, despite winning the election.

Iran's security forces reportedly arrested four people, including three senior reformist politicians, for attempting to "disrupt the country's social and political order" and working "for the benefit" of Israel and America. Earlier an Iranian court sentenced Narges Mohammadi, a human-rights advocate and Nobel peace prize laureate, to seven-and-a-half additional years in prison. She has spent more than a decade imprisoned for various anti-government offences.

Israel's cabinet approved measures to make it easier for Jewish settlers to buy and register land in the **West Bank**. The country's hawkish defence and finance ministers, Israel Katz and Bezalel Smotrich, said that repealing Jordanian-era laws that ban land sales to Jews would remove "decades-old barriers" to development in the territory. Palestine's presidency said the new measures amount to "annexation and displacement". It called them "illegal, null and void".

Morgan McSweeney resigned as **Sir Keir Starmer's** chief of staff. He had encouraged the prime minister to appoint Peter Mandelson as Britain's ambassador to America despite Lord Mandelson's links to Jeffrey Epstein, a dead sex offender. Mr McSweeney was an architect of Labour's resounding electoral victory in 2024. His resignation is unlikely to quell speculation about a challenge to Sir Keir's leadership.

The Seattle Seahawks beat the New England Patriots to win the **Super Bowl**, thanks to a dominant defensive display. **Bad Bunny**, a Puerto Rican singer, became the first Latin star singing primarily in Spanish to headline the half-time show. He did not take a direct swipe at Donald Trump, despite speculation that he might.

Figure of the day: $660bn. The collective sum Alphabet, Amazon, Meta and Microsoft have pledged to spend on AI in the coming year. Read the full story.

What's so special about Moltbook? Whose face appeared on a restored fresco in Rome? Test your knowledge of the week's events with our pint-sized news quiz.

Photograph: Getty Images

Jimmy Lai is sentenced in Hong Kong

On Monday Jimmy Lai was sentenced to a total of 20 years in prison for collusion with foreign forces and of sedition, crimes under Hong Kong's national-security law. The 78-year-old media mogul has already spent nearly five years behind bars for unauthorised assembly and fraud.

Mr Lai's support for greater freedom in China began after the Tiananmen Square massacre of 1989. Through his newspapers he backed the millions of pro-democracy Hong Kongers who marched first in 2014 and again in 2019. He was among the first people charged under a draconian national-security law that took effect in 2020. The specially selected judges presiding over his case found he was "the mastermind" behind "conspiracies to commit collusion" and sedition.

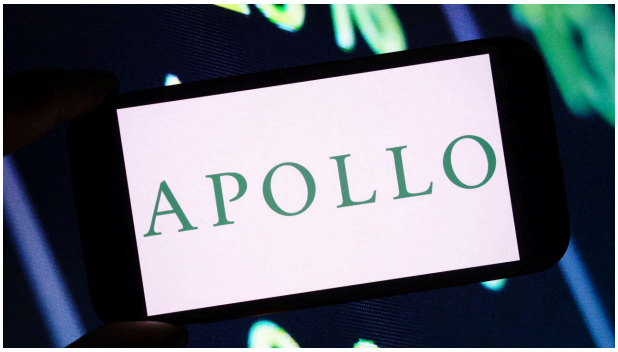
Western governments will probably criticise Monday's sentence. Britain and the European Union have already called Mr Lai's treatment "politically motivated persecution". Authorities in Hong Kong and China, who naturally deny this, will hope they move on quickly. Yet sympathetic Hong Kongers who queued for days to watch the sentencing—some of whom cried at the verdict—may yet honour him as a martyr.

Photograph: Getty Images

Gaza’s phoney peace

In the four months since the end of the war in Gaza several peace-promoting institutions have been established, but they have yet to improve people’s lives. There is a National Committee for the Administration of Gaza, but its members are stuck in Egypt, waiting for Israeli permission to enter the territory. An American military-led co-ordination centre in Israel opened in October to draft plans for the demilitarisation and reconstruction of the strip. A Board of Peace, launched in Davos in January, is scheduled to meet for the first time in Washington on February 19th.

But since the start of the ceasefire Israeli strikes have killed some 500 people in Gaza. The strip remains split between Hamas, which controls the populated areas and refuses to disarm, and the Israeli armed forces, which control the borders and a string of outposts in the territory. Since February 1st a trickle of Gazans, mainly sick and wounded, have been allowed through the Rafah crossing into Egypt. But 2m people are huddled, mostly in tents and ruins, waiting for a breakthrough.



Photograph: Alamy

Apollo’s earnings, oracular implications

Apollo Global Management, a private-equity firm, reports earnings on Monday. Even though Apollo beat analysts’ estimates in its last report, investors have been pessimistic about the private-equity industry, and thus about Apollo: its shares have fallen by 14% this year because of worries about the sector’s exposure to private credit. Last year, private-credit darlings such as First Brands, a car-parts manufacturer, and Tricolor, an auto lender, went bankrupt. Jamie Dimon, the boss of JPMorgan Chase, a bank, warned that more “cockroaches” would appear. Marc Rowan, Apollo’s head, replied that he was serene about Apollo’s loan book, though he said his appetite for risk had fallen due to high interest rates and asset prices.

Apollo says its focus is now on the “picks and shovels” of artificial intelligence. Firms that make these will succeed even if developers of software run into trouble, Apollo argues. In January it joined a $5.4bn deal backing a company that provides data centres to power Elon Musk’s xAI. It acquired a majority stake in another data-centre firm last year. But if AI proves to be a bubble, it’s not certain that hardware firms will escape the consequences when it bursts.

Photograph: Getty Images

Solving problems while you sleep

When you can't solve a problem, sometimes your dreams can provide the answer, or so it has long been thought. A new study published in *Neuroscience of Consciousness*, a journal, gives support to that idea. Researchers at Northwestern University in Illinois asked 20 "lucid dreamers"—people who report that they are often aware when they're dreaming—to attempt to solve brain-teasers. During the problem-solving process the researchers played an audio cue for each puzzle.

Then they observed the participants' brain activity while they slept. When participants entered rapid-eye-movement sleep, a type associated with dreaming, the researchers replayed the audio cues linked to some of the unsolved puzzles. Upon waking three-quarters of the participants reported dreams that included themes associated with those puzzles. When they tried to solve the puzzles again, they were more than twice as likely to solve puzzles that appeared in their dreams as puzzles that did not. Next, the researchers want to explore what else dreams might be able to do, such as regulating emotions and helping people learn. Something to sleep on.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: In which Hans Christian Andersen tale does the main character turn out to be a swan?

There is no subject so old that something new cannot be said about it.

Fyodor Dostoyevsky